# Communication & Soft Skills for Placement Success

Session 2 — A 2-Hour Intensive Workshop for Engineering Students



# Last Class — Quick Recap

## Communication

Exchange of information, ideas & emotions between sender and receiver

## 3 Types

Verbal, Non-verbal, Written,

## SMCR Model

Sender → Message → Channel → Receiver + Feedback loop

## 7 Cs

Clear, Concise, Concrete, Correct, Coherent, Complete, Courteous

## Why English?

Global business language — required for placements, interviews & corporate growth

# Today's Session — What We'll Cover

## 4D Time Management

Eisenhower Urgent-Important Matrix

## SMART Goal Setting

Turn dreams into deadlines

## Interview Etiquette & FAQs

First impressions + top questions answered

## SWOT of Self

Know yourself before the interviewer does

## Activity + Closing

Professional dressing demo, recap & open Q&A

CHAPTER 1

# 4D Time Management

# Eisenhower Matrix

Stop reacting to everything. Start prioritizing what actually matters.





# What Is the 4D Technique?

> *"The urgent are not important, and the important are never urgent."*
> — President Dwight Eisenhower

Popularized by Stephen Covey in *The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People*, this technique helps you stop reacting to everything and start prioritizing what actually matters.

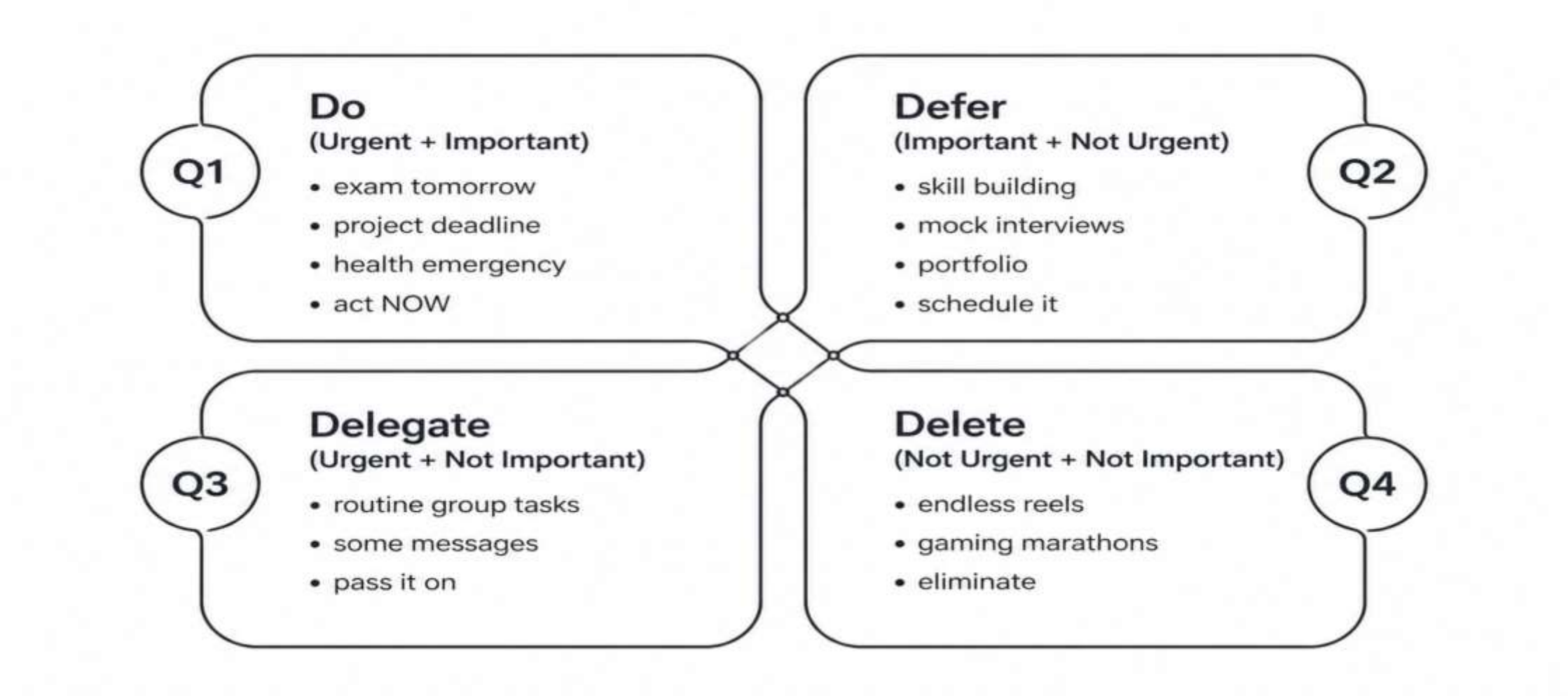
## Do

## Defer

## Delegate

## Delete

# The 4 Quadrants Explained




Most engineering students swing between Q1 (firefighting mode) and Q4 (distraction mode). The goal is to spend more time in **Q2 — where real growth happens.**

# Where Are You Spending Your Time?

### ❌ Most Students — Q1 & Q4

Always firefighting last-minute deadlines OR wasting hours on reels and games. No real progress.

### ✅ Placement-Ready Students — Q2

They prepare *before* the deadline hits. Mock interviews done. Skills built. Confidence ready.

### The 80/20 Rule

Spend 80% of your free time in Q2 → results compound over weeks. Small daily effort = big placement win.

### Try This Today

List 5 tasks right now → assign each a quadrant (Q1/Q2/Q3/Q4) → act accordingly.



CHAPTER 2

# SMART Goal Setting Framework

# Turn Dreams into Deadlines

A wish without a deadline is just a dream. Let's change that — right now.

# Why Most Goals Fail



## → Vague = Zero Accountability

**"I want to get placed"** is a wish, not a goal. No clarity = no action.

## → No Deadline = Optional

Without a fixed date, the brain will always say "I'll do it tomorrow."

## → No Measurement = No Progress

Without tracking, you never know if you're actually improving.

## → The Fix — Make It SMART

**Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound**

# The SMART Framework

### S — Specific
Exactly what do you want? **"Crack TCS interview"** — not just "get a job"

### M — Measurable
How will you track it? Mock scores, practice rounds, feedback ratings — use numbers

### A — Achievable
Realistic given your current skills and time available — stretch but don't break

### R — Relevant
Does it directly help your placement goal? If not, it can wait

### T — Time-bound
Fixed deadline — **"by March 31st"**, **"in 8 weeks"** — no open-ended goals

# SMART Goals in Action

| Topic | ❌ Weak Goal | ✅ SMART Goal |
|---|---|---|
| Interviews | "Get better at interviews" | Complete 10 mock interviews, score 8/10 on communication by March 31st |
| English | "Improve English" | Reduce filler words to under 5 per minute, practice 3x/week for 8 weeks |
| Coding | "Learn coding" | Solve 2 LeetCode problems daily, complete 60 problems by April 15th |

✍ **Activity:** Write 2 SMART goals for your placement journey — right now, in your notebook. Don't leave this room without them.



CHAPTER 3

# Interview Etiquette & Top FAQs

# First Impressions Win

What you do before you speak matters just as much as what you say.

# Before You Enter the Room

- [ ] **Research the Company**
  Know their products, values, recent news, and LinkedIn profile of interviewers — walk in prepared, not surprised

- [ ] **Arrive 10–15 Minutes Early**
  Not more, not less — too early seems desperate, late is disqualifying

- [ ] **Dress Formally**
  Ironed shirt, dark trousers, polished shoes, subtle tie — no wrinkles, no casual wear

- [ ] **Carry Your Documents**
  3 copies of resume, original certificates, notepad, pen — be ready for anything

- [ ] **Phone on Silent**
  Not vibrate — **silent.** A buzzing phone in an interview is an instant red flag



# The First 30 Seconds Matter Most

Interviewers form **70% of their opinion in the first 30 seconds** — make every second count.

### Handshake

Firm (not crushing), 2–3 seconds, direct eye contact, natural smile

### Greeting

"Good morning sir/ma'am, thank you for this opportunity" — warm, confident tone

### Posture

Sit upright, feet flat, hands on table or lap — no slouching, no fidgeting

### Eye Contact

Look at the interviewer — not the floor, not the ceiling, not your hands

# Top FAQs — What They Ask & What They Want

## "Tell me about yourself"

90-second pitch: education → skills → 1 achievement → why this role. Practice till it flows naturally.

## "Why this company?"

Show research — mention their product, values, or a recent project. Generic answers are spotted immediately.

## "What is your weakness?"

Be honest + show improvement: *"I used to procrastinate, now I use the 4D matrix to stay on track."*

## "Where in 5 years?"

Show ambition + alignment with company growth — not just "I want to be a manager."

## "Any questions for us?"

Always YES — ask about team culture, growth path, or day-to-day work. Silence here is a missed opportunity.

CHAPTER 4

# SWOT Analysis

# Know Yourself

If you don't know your own gaps, the interviewer will find them for you.





# What Is a Personal SWOT?

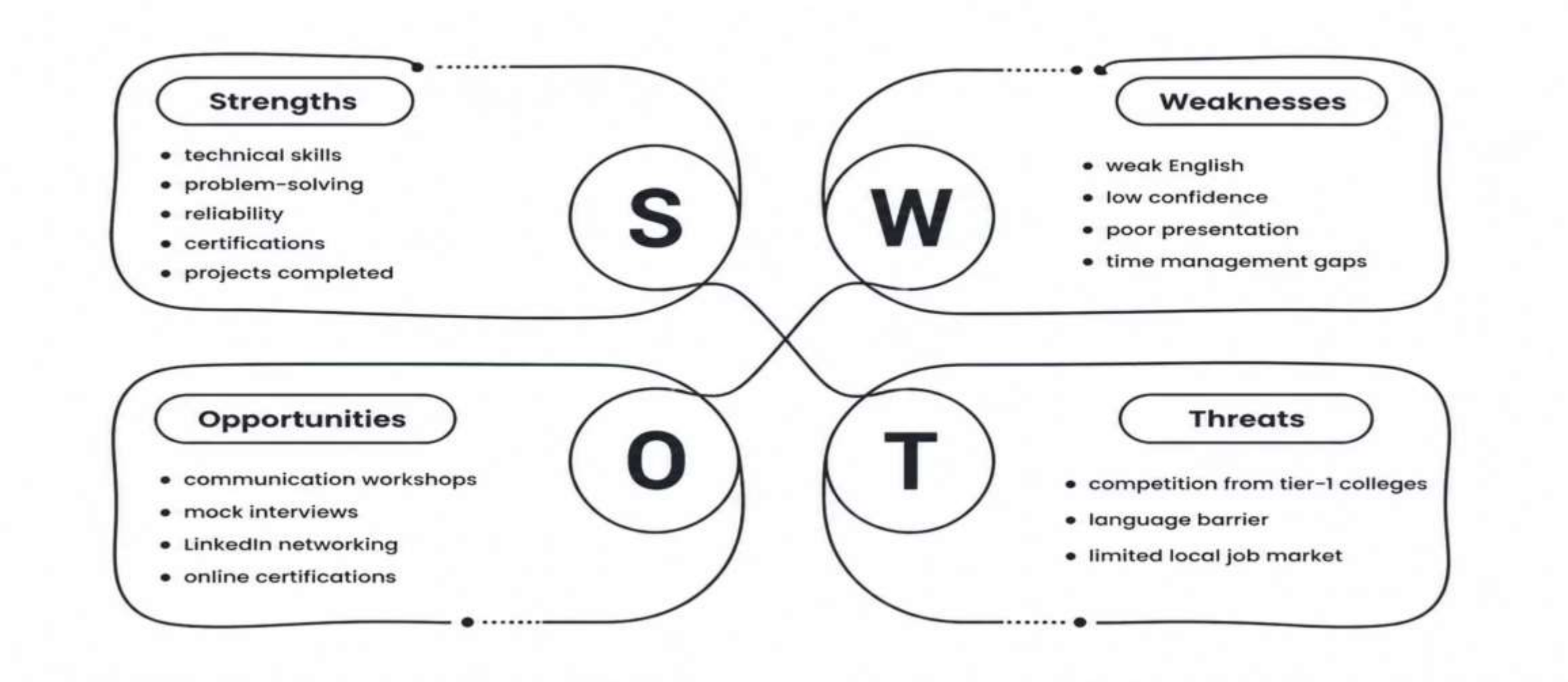
SWOT = **S**trengths, **W**eaknesses, **O**pportunities, **T**hreats

Originally a business strategy tool — it is equally powerful for personal career planning. It forces you to look both **inward (S, W)** and **outward (O, T).**

## Why It Matters for You

Knowing your strengths lets you showcase them confidently. Knowing your weaknesses lets you either fix them or frame them positively — before the interviewer brings them up.

# Build Your Personal SWOT




**Strategy:** Amplify your strengths + actively fix your weaknesses = your competitive edge over tier-1 students.

# SWOT → Action Plan

1

## Strength → Showcase It

Strong in coding? Build a GitHub portfolio. Mention it in every interview. Let your work speak.

2

## Weakness → Fix It

Poor English? Speak 10 minutes of English daily, record yourself, review and improve every week.

3

## Opportunity → Grab It

Workshop happening? Attend. Internship open? Apply immediately. Mentor available? Ask now.

4

## Threat → Prepare for It

Tier-1 competition? Outwork them on communication & attitude — that is where YOU can win.

ACTIVITY

## Soft Skills Activity

# Professional Dressing & Tie-Tying

You have the skills. Now let's make sure you look the part too.





# Why Dressing Matters in Placements

## 7s

### First Impression

You are judged in just 7 seconds — before you say a single word

## 20%

### Competence Boost

Well-dressed candidates are rated 20% more competent in initial screening

Many tier-3 students lose marks not on knowledge — but on appearance & body language. This is fully in your control.

**Rule:** Dress for the job you want, not the college you're in.

# The Professional Dressing Checklist



## Shirt

Crisp, ironed, white or light blue — no prints, no wrinkles, always tucked in



## Trousers

Dark (black/navy/grey), well-fitted, creased, full length to shoe



## Shoes

Polished leather, black or brown — absolutely no sneakers, no sandals



## Tie

Solid color or subtle pattern — tip must reach the belt buckle, no more, no less



## Grooming

Clean nails, trimmed hair, light cologne — no overpowering scent, stay subtle




CHAPTER 5

# Color Psychology in Professional Dressing

# Colors Speak Louder

Every color you wear sends a message — understand it, and use it to your advantage in placements.

# What Your Outfit Color Says About You

Every color you choose sends a non-verbal message. Master color psychology to project confidence and professionalism in your interviews.

## Navy Blue

**Trustworthy, Confident, Leadership** — This is universally considered the best color for interviews, conveying reliability and authority without being aggressive.

## White

**Clean, Honest, Organized** — Ideal for shirts, white symbolizes clarity and attention to detail. Always crisp and ironed.

## Grey

**Neutral, Analytical, Professional** — A safe, versatile choice that communicates sophistication and practicality. Opt for charcoal grey for more impact.

## Black

**Authority, Power, Formality** — While powerful, black can sometimes appear unapproachable. Use sparingly, perhaps for a blazer, or combine with softer colors.

## Light Blue

**Calm, Approachable, Communicative** — A good alternative to white for shirts, signaling a cooperative and composed demeanor.

## Brown/Beige

**Reliable, Warm, Grounded** — These earthy tones convey stability and approachability, making you seem more down-to-earth. Ensure they are well-matched with other colors.

## Red

**Bold, Energetic, Passionate** — Red demands attention. Use only as a small accent (e.g., a tie, pocket square) to show dynamism, never for a full outfit.

**Colors to Avoid:** Steer clear of bright yellow, neon shades, and loud prints. These are highly distracting and can detract from your professional image, making you appear unprofessional.



# Accessories That Speak

Every detail matters. Subtle, well-chosen accessories can reinforce your professional image, while flashy or inappropriate ones can distract. Choose wisely.

## Watch

Wear on **left wrist**. Analog preferred over digital/smartwatch. Simple dial, leather or metal strap — no flashy sports watches.

## Rings

Max **1 ring per hand**. Avoid chunky/flashy rings. Wedding or religious rings are generally acceptable.

## Belt

Always **match belt color to shoe color** (black shoes = black belt, brown shoes = brown belt).

## Socks

Dark colored, **matching trousers** — never white socks with formal shoes. Avoid novelty patterns.

## Wallet & Pen

Keep it **clean and minimal** — no torn bags, no overstuffed pockets. Carry a good quality pen to signal preparedness.

## Avoid These

Multiple chains, earrings (for men), heavy bangles, loud bracelets. **Accessories should complement, not compete** with, your professionalism.

# Grooming Tips That Get You Noticed

Your appearance is a powerful non-verbal cue. Master these essential grooming details to project professionalism and meticulousness, demonstrating you're ready for the role.

## Hair

Neatly combed, no messy or wet look. Avoid extreme styles or colors that might distract from your professional demeanor.

## Face

Clean shaven, or a neatly trimmed and maintained beard. Avoid any stubble or patchy beard that suggests a lack of care.

## Nails

Trimmed short and clean. Ensure there's no dirt under your nails. Men should avoid nail polish.

## Skin

Keep your skin moisturized. Use a light face wash before the interview and ensure no visible acne marks are uncovered.

## Scent

Use cologne or deodorant sparingly — 1-2 sprays max. Apply about 30 minutes before the interview so it's subtle, not overpowering.

## Teeth & Breath

Ensure your teeth are brushed and your breath is fresh. Carry a mint and avoid strong-smelling foods before your interview.

## Hands

Keep them clean and dry. A sweaty handshake can leave a negative impression. Wash your hands thoroughly before entering.

## Posture

Stand tall, shoulders back, and chin parallel to the floor. Confident posture communicates self-assurance before you even speak.

**Simple Rule:** You should look like you already work there. Dress and groom as if you're already a valued member of their team.



# Confidence Boosters for Interviews

Building confidence isn't just about feeling better; it's about projecting an aura of capability and calm. These practical tips are designed to help you feel and appear more confident in high-pressure situations like interviews.

## Power Pose

Before entering, stand in a "superhero pose" for 2 minutes. This scientifically reduces stress hormones and boosts confidence.

## Mirror Practice

Practice speaking in a mirror daily for 5 minutes. Observe your expressions, eye contact, and smile to refine your delivery.

## The 3-Second Rule

When nervous, take a slow, deliberate 3-second breath before answering. It shows control, not hesitation, and buys you time.

## Daily Affirmations

Start each morning with positive affirmations: "I am prepared. I am capable. I belong here." Repeat 3 times.

## Preparation is Key

The more you prepare, the less you fear. Mock interviews, SWOT analysis, and SMART goals build genuine confidence.

## Speak Slowly

Nervous people tend to speak fast. Deliberately slow down your speech; it makes you sound more confident and allows you to think clearly.

## Smile First

A genuine smile before you speak instantly makes you more likeable and helps you relax. It creates a positive first impression.

## Professional Pause

If you forget an answer, say: "That's a great question, let me think for a moment." This buys you time and sounds composed.



# Interview Cheat Codes: Unlock Your Potential

Ready to stand out? These aren't your typical interview tips. We've compiled advanced, insider strategies designed to give you an edge and make you memorable to recruiters. Think of them as your secret playbook for campus placements!

## The Name Game

Use the interviewer's name once or twice naturally – e.g., *"That's a great point, Mr. Sharma."* It builds instant rapport and shows you're attentive.

## The Echo Technique

Repeat the last 2-3 words of their question before answering. This subtly shows active listening and buys you a split second to formulate your thoughts.

## The Pause-and-Pivot

If stumped, say: *"I haven't worked on that specifically, but here's how I'd approach it..."* – it highlights your problem-solving mindset, not just memorized answers.

## The Callback

Reference something from earlier: *"As I mentioned about my project..."* This demonstrates engagement, coherence, and strong memory.

## The Enthusiasm Trick

End every answer with a forward-looking statement: *"...and I'm excited to bring this skill to your team."* It showcases your passion and future orientation.

## The Research Drop

Casually mention a specific fact about the company: *"I noticed your company recently launched X."* It instantly impresses with your dedicated preparation.

## The Notebook Move

Bring a notepad and jot down 1-2 notes during the interview. This signals seriousness, active engagement, and attention to detail.

## The Thank You Email

Send a short, personalized thank-you email within 24 hours. Less than 5% of candidates do this, making you truly memorable!

# Know Your Collar: Types of Jobs by Color

As you embark on your professional journey, particularly in engineering, understanding the diverse landscape of work is crucial. Job types are often categorized by "collar" colors, reflecting common characteristics of the roles. This overview will help you appreciate various professions and navigate diverse workplace interactions.

## White Collar

These are **office-based, professional, managerial, or administrative jobs**. Think engineers, managers, bankers, and IT professionals. They typically involve mental work, often in a formal dress code.

## Blue Collar

Refers to **skilled manual labor or trade jobs**. This includes electricians, mechanics, plumbers, and factory workers. These roles involve physical work, often in uniforms or protective gear.

## Pink Collar

Covers **service and care sector jobs** that traditionally involve people-focused roles. Examples include nurses, teachers, receptionists, and HR professionals, often requiring strong interpersonal skills.

## Brown Collar

These roles are primarily associated with **agriculture, farming, and forestry**. This work is typically outdoors and land-based, contributing to food production and natural resource management.

## Green Collar

An expanding sector focusing on **environmentally friendly and sustainable jobs**. This includes roles in solar energy, environmental engineering, conservation, and eco-friendly manufacturing.

## Gold Collar

Designates **highly specialized professionals with rare expertise** and often premium pay. This category includes top-tier doctors, lawyers, pilots, and elite engineers whose skills are in high demand.

## Grey Collar

A blend of blue and white-collar work, these are **semi-skilled jobs** that often require both technical knowledge and practical application. Examples are lab assistants, technicians, and security personnel.

**For engineering students like you:** You are entering the White Collar world. Understanding all collar types fosters respect for every profession and enhances your ability to communicate effectively in diverse workplaces.

# Telling Time Like a Professional: English Time Expressions

Mastering time communication is vital in any professional setting. This guide will help you confidently express time in English and understand common abbreviations used in the workplace, ensuring smooth coordination and clear understanding with your colleagues.

## How to Say the Time in English

A simple rule: Use **"past"** for the first 30 minutes and **"to"** for the last 30 minutes. Use **"quarter"** for 15 minutes and **"half"** for 30 minutes.

### 3:00
Three o'clock

### 3:15
Quarter past three

### 3:30
Half past three

### 3:45
Quarter to four

### 3:05
Five past three

### 3:55
Five to four

### 12:00 PM
Noon / Midday

### 12:00 AM
Midnight

## Professional Time Abbreviations

These abbreviations are common in professional emails, chats, and calendars. Knowing them helps you understand expectations quickly.

### ETA
Estimated Time of Arrival
(When will you reach?)

### ASAP
As Soon As Possible
(Do it urgently)

### EOD
End of Day
(by 5–6 PM today)

### COB
Close of Business
(Same as EOD)

### EOM
End of Month

### TBD
To Be Decided / Determined
(Time not fixed yet)

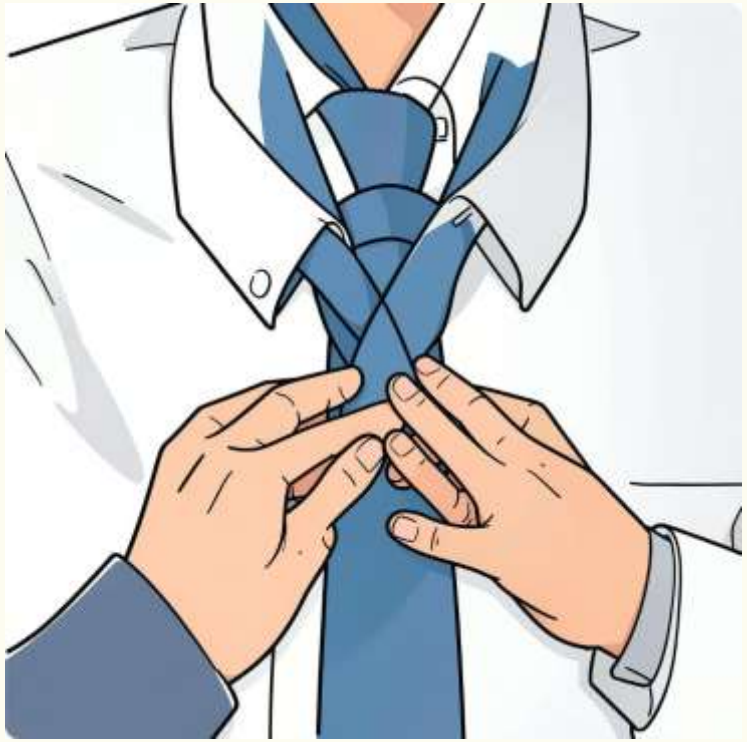
### OOO
Out of Office
(On leave / not available)

### FYI
For Your Information

### WFH
Work From Home

### DOJ
Date of Joining

# How to Tie a Tie — Step by Step



1. Drape tie around collar — wide end on right, 12 inches longer than narrow end
2. Cross the wide end over the narrow end (left to right)
3. Wrap wide end underneath and behind the narrow end (right to left)
4. Bring wide end back across the front again (left to right)
5. Pull wide end up through the neck loop from underneath
6. Slide wide end down through the front knot — tighten gently, adjust to collar button

👔 **Practice time:** Everyone try it now — help your neighbour if they're stuck! You've got this.



CLOSING

# Closing the Loop

# Let's Wrap Up

Everything you learned today is a tool. Use it. Practice it. Own it.

# Session Recap — What You Learned Today

## 4D Matrix

Do, Defer, Delegate, Delete — live in Q2 for real, compounding growth

## SMART Goals

Specific + Measurable + Achievable + Relevant + Time-bound = actual results

## Interview Etiquette

Research, arrive early, dress sharp, answer every question with confidence

## SWOT of Self

Know your strengths, own your weaknesses, grab opportunities, beat threats

## Professional Dressing

First impression is a skill — practice it like any other skill you want to master

# Your 30-Day Placement Action Plan

## Week 1

Complete your personal SWOT + write 2 SMART placement goals in your notebook

1

## Week 2

Apply 4D matrix to your daily schedule — track how you spend every hour for 7 days

2

## Week 3

Do 3 mock interviews with a friend — record yourself, review, and improve each time

3

## Week 4

Finalize resume, practice tie-tying, invest in one complete formal outfit for interviews

4

## Ongoing 🔁

Speak English 10 min/day, read company news, build & update your LinkedIn profile

5

# Closing Inspiration: Words of Wisdom

"The way we communicate with others and with ourselves ultimately determines the quality of our lives."
— Tony Robbins

"It takes 20 years to build a reputation and five minutes to ruin it. If you think about that, you'll do things differently."
— Warren Buffett

"Your time is limited, so don't waste it living someone else's life."
— Steve Jobs

"Believe you can and you're halfway there."
— Theodore Roosevelt

"The secret of getting ahead is getting started."
— Mark Twain

"You don't have to be great to start, but you have to start to be great."
— Zig Ziglar

Your placement journey starts today. Take the first step.

# Open Floor — Questions & Doubts 🎯

This is your time. Ask anything — time management, goal-setting, interview prep, dressing, English communication, or anything holding you back from getting placed.

> **"The student who asks questions today is the one who gets placed tomorrow."**
> No question is too small. Let's go! 🎯

### 💬 Communication & English

How to speak confidently? How to reduce filler words? Ask away.

### Time & Goals

Struggling with the 4D matrix or writing SMART goals? Let's work it out together.

### 👔 Interview & Dressing

Nervous about the interview room? Unsure about formal wear? No judgement here.

